

JAHANGIRNAGAR UNIVERSITY

DEPARTMENT OF ENGLISH

BA (HONOURS) 4TH YEAR FINAL EXAMINATION QUESTION BANK

COURSE CODE: E 402

COURSE TITLE: 20th Century North American Literature I

Target Stream: Concentration on Applied
Linguistics & ELT

Batches Included: 42, 43, 44, 46, 47, 48, 49, 50 (Batch 45 missing)

CURRENT SYLLABUS REFERENCE & SCOPE (Session: 2021–2022, Batch 51)

POETRY:

• **Robert Frost:** "Mending Wall," "Home Burial," "The Road Not Taken," "Birches," "Stopping by the Woods on a Snowy Evening," "Out, Out—," "Design"

• **Sylvia Plath:** "Daddy," "Lady Lazarus," "Ariel"

DRAMA:

• **Eugene O'Neill:** *Long Day's Journey into Night*

• **Arthur Miller:** *Death of a Salesman*

FICTION:

• **William Faulkner:** *As I Lay Dying*

• **Ernest Hemingway:** "Cat in the Rain," "A Clean, Well-lighted Place," "The Short Happy Life of Francis Macomber"

• **Toni Morrison:** *The Bluest Eye*

SECTION A: BROAD QUESTIONS (Essay & Analytical Questions)

Comprehensive broad questions from past final examinations, categorized by prescribed syllabus authors and texts.

1. Robert Frost

1. Examine Frost's treatment of metaphors in his poems. [50]
2. How do Robert Frost's poetic choices shape his approaches to the human condition and the natural world? Discuss. [49]
3. "Life is shown in Robert Frost's poems to contain many aspects of darkness, which often seem concatenated in a series of depressions of the human spirit." Discuss this statement with reference to the poems that you have read. [48]
4. In many poems of Robert Frost there is a recurrent use of the Keatsian notion of "negative capability". Discuss with reference to the poems that you have read. [47]
5. Write a note on Robert Frost's poems that you have read and show how they deal with complex social and philosophical themes. [46]
6. Robert Frost's poetry reveals the paradoxes of human life. Discuss. [44]
7. Robert Frost's poems explore the relationship between humanity and nature. — Do you agree? Explain. [43]

2. Sylvia Plath

1. Analyse Sylvia Plath's poetic techniques with reference to "Lady Lazarus" and "Ariel". [50]
2. How does Sylvia Plath's poetry interrogate the boundaries between victimhood and agency? In "Daddy" and "Lady Lazarus", how does the speaker's transformation from suffering to rage reflect agency? [49]

3. Eugene O'Neill: Long Day's Journey into Night

1. In *Long Day's Journey into Night*, the characters struggle with inner anguish and use different psychological defence mechanisms to escape their past. Discuss with reference to the text. [50]

2. In what ways do *Long Day's Journey into Night* and *Death of a Salesman* depict the impact of family conflict on individual self-identity? [49]
3. "In *Long Day's Journey into Night*, all characters are obsessed with their past guilt." Justify this statement. [48, 46]
4. Discuss *Long Day's Journey into Night* as a modern tragedy. [47]
5. Mary represents the Tyrones' pathetic obsession with their past. Do you agree? Justify your answer. [44]
6. The Tyrones in *Long Day's Journey into Night* are stuck in their (concept of) home and bewildered at the same time in their intensifying sense of homelessness. — Explain. [43]
7. "None of us can help the things that life has done to us. They're done before you realize it... and you've lost your true self forever." Do you think that this comment focuses on the principal theme of *Long Day's Journey into Night*? [42]

4. Arthur Miller: Death of a Salesman

1. Evaluate *Death of a Salesman* as a critique of America's myth of success. [50, 47]
2. Discuss how the death of Willy Loman is caused by his misleading American Dream. [46]
3. How and why is Biff different from the rest of the Lomans? Discuss. [48]

5. William Faulkner: As I Lay Dying

1. In what ways does *As I Lay Dying* depict the breakdown of family unity? Discuss with reference to the text. [50]
2. Discuss the experimental narrative techniques and multi-perspectivity in the works of William Faulkner with reference to *As I Lay Dying*. [49]
3. In what ways can Darl be considered a tragic hero in *As I Lay Dying*? Elaborate. [48]
4. What is Cubism? Discuss *As I Lay Dying* as a Cubist novel. [47]
5. "The coffin is a burden to the Bundren family, and it confirms the dysfunctionality of the family structure." Elaborate this statement from your reading of *As I Lay Dying*. [46]
6. Evaluate Faulkner's technique and purpose of using multiple narrators in *As I Lay Dying*. [44]
7. Discuss the structure and the narrative technique of *As I Lay Dying*. [43]
8. Discuss Addie's interior monologue in *As I Lay Dying*. Why do you think it is placed in the middle of the narrative? [42]

6. Ernest Hemingway: Short Stories

1. Discuss the psychological, social and cultural dimensions of modern man's alienation as evident in Hemingway's short stories. [50]
2. "In most of his writings, Hemingway explores the absence of emotional intimacy in human relationships, addressing existential crisis and nihilism." Discuss this statement referring to the texts that you have read. [48]
3. What is Hemingway's Iceberg theory? How did Hemingway apply this technique in his writings? Refer to the texts that you have read. [47]
4. 'Macomber's boyishness is contrasted with Wilson's strong masculinity.' Discuss this statement from your reading of "The Short Happy Life of Francis Macomber". [46]
5. How does Hemingway portray the existential crisis in his short stories? Discuss with reference to the stories you have read. [44, 43]
6. Hemingway's code hero is "a man who lives correctly, following the ideals of honour, courage, and endurance in a world that is sometimes chaotic, often stressful and always painful." — Illustrate. [42]

7. Toni Morrison: The Bluest Eye

1. How does Toni Morrison examine the intersection of race, gender and class in the depiction of violence? How do the experiences of Pecola and other characters reflect broader systemic failures and cultural silences surrounding such violence? [49]
2. Discuss, with examples from *The Bluest Eye*, how Pecola Breedlove and Maureen Peal are foils to each other. [48]
3. "While it is easy to view Cholly as an evil character, Morrison incorporated scenes of Cholly's own tragic childhood to lend an element of sympathy for him." Discuss. [47]
4. To what extent is Cholly to blame for his violence against his family? Which other circumstances may also be to blame? [46]

SECTION B: SHORT NOTES & BRIEF ANALYTICAL QUESTIONS

Short notes covering major motifs, literary concepts, and character sketches.

Short Notes Collection

1. The idea of motherhood in "Cat in the Rain" [50]
2. Confessional poetry (Sylvia Plath) [50]
3. "Good fences make good neighbors" (Frost: "Mending Wall") [50, 46]
4. Yoknapatawpha County [50, 46]
5. The Lost Generation [49]
6. The cat in "Cat in the Rain" [48]
7. Cholly Breedlove [48]
8. The idea of masculinity in the poem, "Out, Out—" [48]
9. Realism in *Long Day's Journey into Night* [48]
10. Soaphead Church [47]
11. Addie's coffin (*As I Lay Dying*) [47, 43]
12. The use of drugs and alcohol in *Long Day's Journey into Night* [47]
13. Grace under pressure (Hemingway) [46]
14. Pecola Breedlove [46]
15. Mary Tyrone [43]
16. The concept of "nada" (Hemingway: "A Clean, Well-lighted Place") [42]
17. Significance of the "Fog Horn" in *Long Day's Journey into Night* [42]
18. Darl in *As I Lay Dying* [42]

SECTION C: EXCERPT EXPLANATIONS & CONTEXTUAL READINGS

Contextual explanations of famous passages and poems from the syllabus.

Contextual Reading: Robert Frost's "Stopping by the Woods on a Snowy Evening" [47, 44]

Explain with reference to the context:

*"The woods are lovely, dark and deep,
But I have promises to keep,
And miles to go before I sleep,
And miles to go before I sleep."*

Contextual Reading: Robert Frost's "The Road Not Taken" [43]

Explain with reference to the context:

*"Two roads diverged in a wood, and I—
I took the one less traveled by,
And that has made all the difference."*